The Internet, as you can see if you look at China today, was always capable of being a zone of selective censorship, and so was every area of computer culture. The cypherpunks get too little credit for breaking the whole thing open and keeping the tools from becoming weapons, exclusively, in the hands of commercial opportunists and political oppressors. The media was so busy warbling about hackers they missed, right under their noses, how the best of them had become cryptographers busy fighting for the freedoms of information that they themselves claimed to be built on. It was a lesson on the moral infirmity of the media: by and large, they took what power was offered to them, and did not, at the dawn of the Internet era, fight to establish freedom of access or freedom from censorship. To this day, they take the technology for granted and miss how it materialised. It was the cypherpunks, or the ‘code rebels’ as Steven Levy called us, who prevented the new technology from merely becoming a tool used by big business and government agencies to spy on populations, or sell to them. Computers could have come preloaded with commercials. Smartphones could have come embedded with surveillance devices. The Internet could have been repressive in a great number of its facets. Emails could have been generally interceptable and lacking in privacy. But a turf war went on, invisibly to most commentators, a battle that guaranteed certain freedoms. It is the basis of today’s understanding – a cypherpunk commonplace – that computer technology can be a major tool in the fight for social change.

At one time, governments wanted to make cryptography illegal, except for themselves in support of their own activities. And this was preparation for how certain governments now view WikiLeaks: they wish to keep control of technology so that it might only serve itself. But this misunderstands the freedoms inscribed into the technology. We fought for it, so that powerful bodies could not merely use data to suit themselves. The whole struggle was about that and still is about that. For some in the libertarian movement, this was essentially about privacy as capitalist freedom, the right to be free of big government, to have your data kept back; but this is my book and I’ll tell you what it meant to me.

The cypherpunk ethos allowed me to think about how best to oppose the efforts of oppressive bodies – governments, corporations, surveillance agencies – to extract data from vulnerable individuals. Regimes often rely on having control of the data, and they can hurt people or oppress them or